Cabinet extends Agniveer service period by 2 years

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The tenure of military cadets recruited under the Agnipath policy has been extended by two years, according to a Union Cabinet decision on Wednesday.

The Cabinet's approval to extend the tenure of cadets to six years from the current four years appears to be either a reform or an attempt to regularise this avenue of short-term military jobs.

Under this, the Agniveer programme, which came into effect in 2022, will now enable the Indian defence forces, as they increasingly refer to themselves, to retain almost 100 per cent of those entering short-term service for six years. Under the original rules, 75 per cent of cadets would exit at the end of four years. Each year, tens of thousands of youth aged 17.5-21 years enrol. At present, 300,000 cadets are in training in the three services.

A total of 46,000 Agniveer cadets in the first batch are set to conclude their training in the coming weeks and months. Of this, some 40,000 are in the army, and some 3,000 each in the navy and the air force. The first batch of Agniveer cadets in the navy complete their four-year training later this month, and those in the air force and the army in December and January, respectively.

Before this announcement, the three services had prepared merit lists to retain only 25 per cent in each, and let 75 per cent go. This would have meant some 35,000 youth with varying degrees of military training would be without employment in the services soon or with only limited prospects of reemployment, as earlier reported by *Business Standard*.

Defence sources said on Wednesday that the services would still internally announce the merit lists, based on which the first 25 per cent would be picked to be absorbed full-time for another 15 years, as earlier mandated by the policy.

The 75 per cent that would get the two-year extension from later this month — if the cadets are willing to stay — would form the second rung of the Agniveer ladder, because it would still be based on merit, Chief of Defence Staff General N S Raja Subramani told a media briefing. The briefing was also addressed by Cabinet spokesman and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw. Both praised the policy, saying that the review was undertaken, encouraged by how well the programme had done over the past four years. They called it "a pathway" for all Agniveer cadets.

"After the two-year extension, all willing Agniveer will be offered and enrolled as regular soldiers," the CDS said, adding that the services want disciplined, motivated people. "The quality of the workforce has to be maintained."

After the 75 per cent complete their two more years of service, all cadets can be "enrolled as regular soldiers, subject to their willingness and (the) meeting selection criteria", the Ministry of Defence said in a statement. It is unclear if that would entail another 12 years or so of continued employment in the three services. The regular short-service commission is up to 14 years.

The Agnipath policy will continue, the statement said, adding that the second engagement will see higher remuneration, enhanced final settlement and "seniority benefits".

In the first four years, the Agniveer cadets are paid between ₹30,000 and ₹40,000 (the take-home is ₹21,000 and ₹28,000, respectively). Now, those who do two more years will get ₹43,500 in the first year and ₹47,500 in the second year (of the extension). The previous tax-free final settlement for those exiting the scheme was ₹10.04 lakh to ₹11.71 lakh. Now, it will start at ₹10.92 lakh. As before, the cadets will not be entitled to any pension.



Updated rulebook

- All who have completed six years can opt to stay back in the armed forces if they meet the requirements
- Policy earlier mandated four years of service
- 25% to be retained on merit; 100% can be retained if "willing" and meet service criteria
- ₹30,000 to ₹40,000 salary in first four years; ₹43,500 to ₹47,500 in the next two